Looking Up: The Night Sky Over Billingborough

15 October – 12 November 2026

A practical guide to the most interesting astronomical events visible from Billingborough

The coming four weeks offer plenty for observers as autumn advances and the nights grow longer. October brings the Orionid meteor shower, while November offers two opportunities to catch the slow, sometimes brilliant Taurid meteors. There will also be a close-looking encounter between the Moon and Saturn, and a darker period around the November new Moon that is ideal for exploring galaxies and star clusters.

At a glance

Date	Event	What to look for
15–20 October	Autumn galaxies and star clusters	Seek out the Andromeda and Triangulum galaxies under dark skies.
21–22 October	Orionid meteor shower	Look for fast meteors from the debris of Halley's Comet.
24 October	Moon near Saturn	Find the ringed planet beside the bright waxing Moon.
25–26 October	Hunter's Moon	The full Moon lights the autumn landscape.
27–28 October	Moon near the Pleiades	Watch the Moon pass close to the Seven Sisters star cluster.
4–6 November	Southern Taurid meteor shower	Look out for occasional slow, bright meteors and fireballs.
9 November	New Moon	A good opportunity for deep-sky observing.
11–12 November	Northern Taurid meteor shower	Another chance to look for bright Taurid meteors.

The autumn nights deepen

As the nights lengthen, there is more time to explore familiar autumn constellations and hunt for faint deep-sky objects. The Moon's changing phase will influence conditions through the month, with the darker nights around new Moon offering the best opportunity for galaxies and star clusters.

21–22 October – The Orionid meteor shower

The Orionids reach their expected peak during the night of 21–22 October. These fast meteors are particles left behind by Halley's Comet as Earth crosses its trail of debris. Rates can reach around 10–20 meteors per hour under ideal conditions, although actual counts are often lower.

A bright waxing Moon will interfere with observations during part of the night, but it is still worth watching for brighter meteors. No telescope or binoculars are needed. Choose a dark spot with a wide view of the sky, allow your eyes 20–30 minutes to adapt, and watch patiently rather than concentrating on Orion itself.

24 October – The Moon meets Saturn

The Moon and Saturn make a useful pairing for locating the ringed planet. Use the Moon as a starting point and look towards the southeastern sky in the evening. Saturn remains a rewarding telescopic target, with its rings visible even in a modest telescope.



The Moon and Saturn in the southeastern evening sky. Sky chart supplied by Billingborough Observatory and generated using Stellarium.

25–26 October – The Hunter's Moon

October's full Moon, traditionally known as the Hunter's Moon, occurs on 26 October. Watch it rise above the eastern horizon around sunset. Its brightness will make faint galaxies harder to see, but it is an excellent naked-eye sight and a good opportunity for lunar photography.

27–28 October – The Moon and the Pleiades

The Moon passes close to the Pleiades (M45), the beautiful open cluster also known as the Seven Sisters. The cluster is visible to the naked eye and especially attractive through binoculars, which reveal many more of its blue-white stars. Moonlight may reduce contrast, but the pairing is still worth looking for.



The Moon close to the Pleiades star cluster. Sky chart supplied by Billingborough Observatory and generated using Stellarium.

4–6 November – The Southern Taurid meteor shower

The Southern Taurids are known for occasional slow, bright meteors, including impressive fireballs. Activity is spread across several weeks, with a broad maximum around 5 November. Typical rates are low, but the chance of seeing a particularly bright meteor makes them worth watching.

9 November – New Moon and dark skies

The new Moon around 9 November provides a good opportunity for deep-sky observing. From Billingborough, try the Andromeda Galaxy, the Double Cluster in Perseus and the Pleiades. Binoculars are an excellent starting point; choose a dark location and allow your eyes to adapt.

11–12 November – The Northern Taurid meteor shower

The Northern Taurids reach their expected maximum around 12 November. Like the Southern Taurids, they have a low rate of activity but can produce an occasional bright fireball. The Moon is a thin waxing crescent around this time, making conditions more favourable than during the Orionids.

A good four weeks for observing

The Orionids offer a chance to catch the fast debris of Halley's Comet, while the Taurids bring the possibility of a brilliant fireball. Saturn remains a rewarding telescopic object, and the Moon's passage near the Pleiades provides an attractive naked-eye and binocular sight. The darker nights around new Moon are the best opportunity to explore galaxies and star clusters.

From Billingborough, a clear night away from local lights should provide plenty to explore. Wrap up warmly, check the forecast before heading outside, and remember that patience is often the most important observing equipment of all.

Sources and checking

Event dates and observing information should be checked against current 2026 astronomical calendars before publication. The two sky charts were supplied by Billingborough Observatory and generated using Stellarium, the free open-source planetarium software: stellarium.org.